STEEPED IN HISTORY
(clockwise from left) The Kirti Toran monument, Hatkeshwar Temple and the Sharmishtha lake



whose highlight is a replica of the *kitli* Modi used to serve tea from

Greening and landscaping of the town has been undertaken, which includes a walkway around the ancient Sharmishtha lake

There are plans to launch a heritage and pilgrimage circuit connecting Vadnagar by rail to Taranga, Siddhpur, Patan and Modhera

The Tana Riri Performing Arts College was established in 2021

to broad gauge with plans announced to connect Vadnagar to Delhi. Last year, the intercity train from Vadnagar to Valsad in south Gujarat was converted into a superfast express. Another MEMU (Mainline Electric Multiple Unit) train runs between Veretha (around 26 km from Vadnagar) and Gandhinagar. Within the town, a third bus terminus is expected to come up soon, along with electric rickshaws to ferry tourists around.

The state government is hoping to draw steady tourist footfalls in the coming years through all these measures—especially events-based tourism activities. Pritam Meity, a tourism official and archaeologist, says the town currently gets around 35,000 visitors a month, though that is expected to rise once the ongoing projects are completed. "As the number of projects increases and when tourism actually starts, this town will be very different. It will be a buzzing centre of cultural activities, generating thousands of jobs," says Meity.

However, exactly how this rush of activity will change the fortunes of Vadnagar's residents, a majority of whom are engaged in farming or are unskilled, is still an unknown. The spotlight on the town has unarguably had its perks. Many of the educational institutes in Vadnagar have come up in the past few years. Among them is the Tana Riri Performing Arts College, which was set up in 2021. On the health front as well, things have improved. A small sub-district hospital in the town that could attend to a handful of people till a few years ago is now a major medical facility. The Vadnagar Heritage Society, set up last year under the chairmanship of the state's chief secretary and comprising senior IAS officers, has been tasked to work with the Centre for the Prerna project.

VADNAGAR RESIDENTS HOPE THAT THE TOURISM PUSH WILL CREATE MORE JOBS AND ENHANCE THE TOWN'S PROGRESS

But the whirlwind progress has thrown up questions too. In March last year, a few residents moved the Gujarat High Court against the state's decision to acquire their land for a buffer zone to protect a few archaeological remains. The court dismissed the plea, quoting the Mahabharata to highlight the spirit of "sacrifice" for public interest. The government had allegedly failed to conduct a social impact assessment to create the buffer zone. "Around 30 families have been given compensation according to existing rules for vacating their houses. Besides, acquisition of agricultural land outside the town is also underway," said Rohit Agrahara, the mamlatdar of Vadnagar.

Another challenge, which is not entirely insurmountable but may require more broad-based solutions, is the immigration fever that has gripped north Gujarat, pushing many to move to big cities or even desperately undertake long—and often perilous—journeys to reach America's shores. The Mehsana and Gandhinagar districts are at the centre of that frenzy. "People leave for a better life," says Rudra Patel, a civil engineer, pointing to the empty *havelis* and quiet bylanes that stand testimony to this exodus. Patel is currently a site engineer at the Prerna project, one of the many locals who have found work under the ongoing conservation or redevelopment initiatives. How long that window of opportunity remains open for Patel and others like him is anybody's guess, though people hope that a rise in tourism will help lower the tide, if not entirely reverse it.

A strange scepticism permeates the town's air for now. Mahesh Makwana, a tailor, is lazily shaking himself out of his afternoon siesta. "Our lives are changing.... Tourism will boost the local economy, I suppose," he says, looking warily at a crane and about a dozen engineers working at the museum construction site near his house. Given the long, harsh neglect that preceded this sudden prominence, perhaps it will take more than just a heritage makeover for Vadnagar's residents to really be optimistic about their future. ■